FORTNIGHTLY SATSANG · SAT-001

# The Divine Mother

## *The One Power That Became All*

या देवी सर्वभूतेषु शक्तिरूपेण संस्थिता

Swami Tadananda · Ramakrishna Vedanta Centre NZ · 25 October 2026

**How to use this handout.** Each slide is followed by Swamiji's notes. Read a few slides at a time, pause on the reflection questions, and try the revision quiz online at ramakrishna-vedanta-centre-nz.github.io/satsangs/SAT-001/quiz

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SLIDE 1

## The Divine Mother

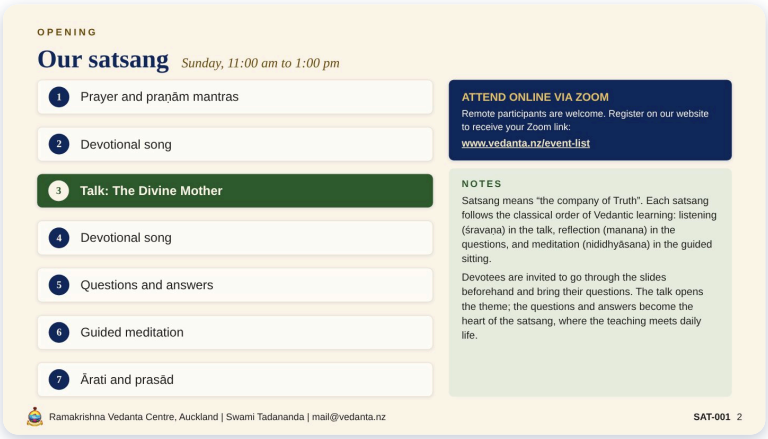



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Welcome everyone, in the room and on Zoom. In the Durgā Pūjā we worship the Divine Mother in the image. Here we ask where else she lives: as the power behind the whole universe, and as the power within our own body, breath, mind, intellect and sense of I. We will close with practices to recognise her and receive her grace in every action.

SLIDE 2

## Our satsang

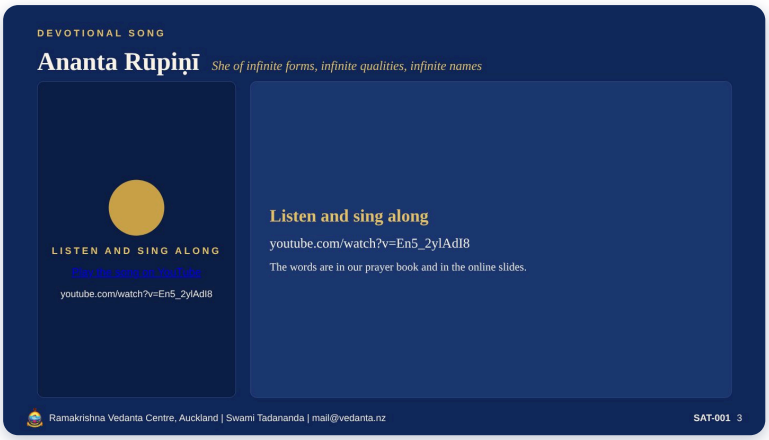



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

The general order of every satsang, 11:00 am to 1:00 pm, kept flexible with no fixed times. The Yā Devī chant is sung within the talk. The talk is about one hour and moves through five parts: the Mother one with Brahman; she has become all; she within us; the Ramakrishna tradition's living worship; and practices for realising her grace.

SLIDE 3

## Ananta Rūpiṇī

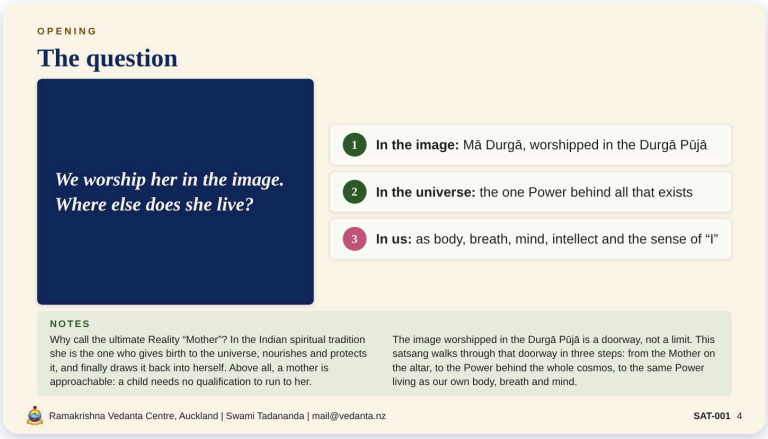



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Devotional song: Ananta Rūpiṇī. Recording: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=En5_2ylAdI8 . The three epithets set the theme of the satsang: the Mother has infinite forms (the universe), infinite qualities (her powers within us) and infinite names (the many ways we call on her).

SLIDE 4

## The question




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Begin with the Durgā Pūjā. Ask: we worship her in the image, but where else does she live? The answer is the arc of the talk: in the image, in the universe, and in us. For newcomers, explain why the Indian spiritual tradition calls the ultimate Reality Mother: she creates, sustains and dissolves, and above all she is approachable. A child does not need qualifications to go to its mother.

SLIDE 5

# Fire and its power to burn

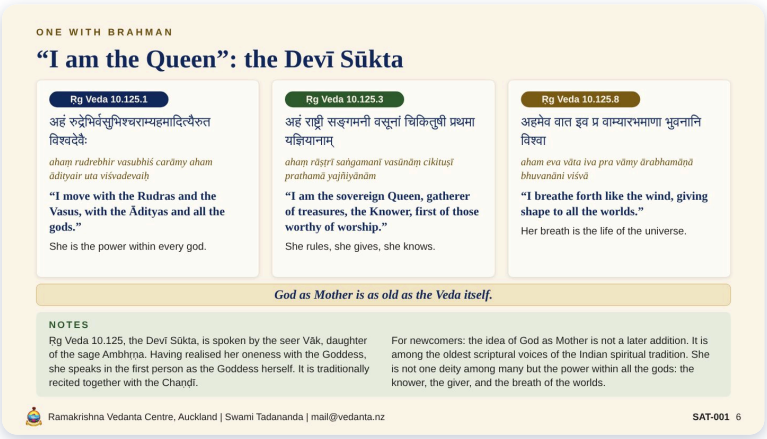



## SWAMIJI’S NOTES

The foundation of the talk. The Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna (tr. Swami Nikhilananda): “When I think of the Supreme Being as inactive, neither creating nor preserving nor destroying, I call Him Brahman or Purusha, the Impersonal God. When I think of Him as active, creating, preserving and destroying, I call Him Sakti or Maya or Prakriti, the Personal God. But the distinction between them does not mean a difference.

SLIDE 6

# “I am the Queen”: the Devī Sūkta

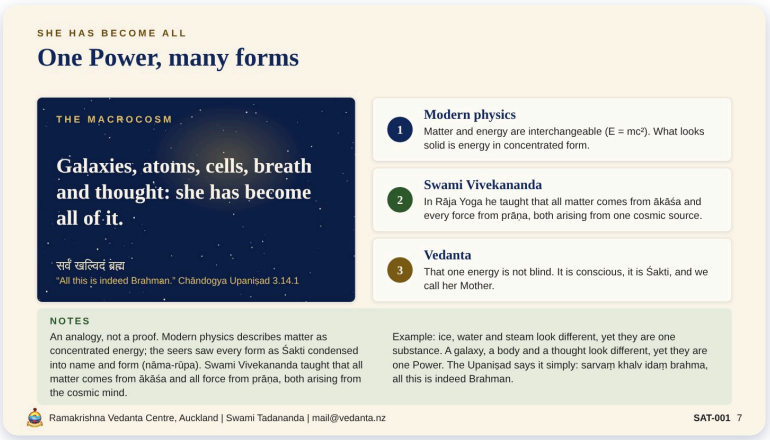



## SWAMIJI’S NOTES

The Devī Sūkta (Ṛg Veda 10.125), eight verses, also called the Vāk Sūkta. The seer Vāk Āmbhṛṇī speaks as the Goddess. Verse 1: she moves with all the groups of gods. Verse 3: she is the sovereign queen (rāṣṭrī), gatherer of wealth, the knowing one (cikituṣī). Verse 8: she breathes forth like the wind, beginning (giving shape to) all the worlds. It is traditionally recited before the Chaṇḍī.

SLIDE 7

# One Power, many forms

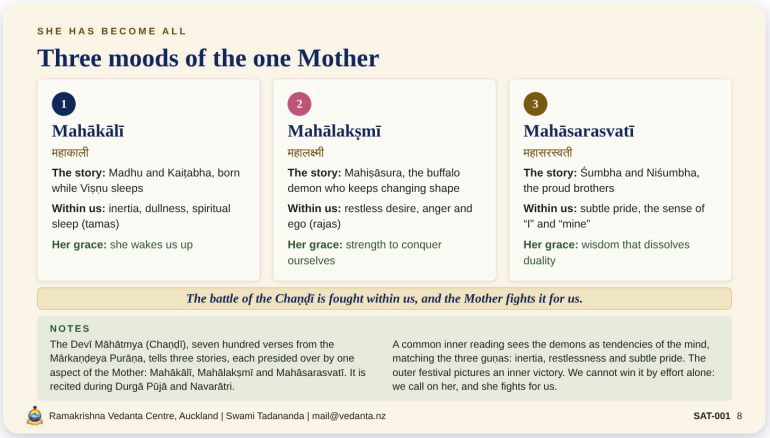



## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

The macrocosm. The starfield on the left twinkles slowly. Swami Vivekananda, Rāja Yoga, chapter on Prāṇa: the whole universe is made of two materials, ākāśa (the all-pervading existence from which all matter comes) and prāṇa (the infinite power from which all force comes), both of which arise from Mahat, the cosmic mind. Present the physics as an analogy that helps us picture the teaching, not as a proof. Chāndogya Upaniṣad 3.14.1: sarvaṃ khalv idaṃ brahma.

SLIDE 8

# Three moods of the one Mother




## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Three episodes of the Chaṇḍī. First (chapter 1), presided over by Mahākālī: the demons Madhu and Kaiṭabha arise while Viṣṇu sleeps; the Devī as Yoganidrā withdraws from him so he wakes. Inner meaning: tamas, the sleep of the spirit; her grace awakens us. Middle (chapters 2 to 4), Mahālakṣmī: Mahiṣāsura keeps changing form, like desire and anger. Inner meaning: rajas. Last (chapters 5 to 13), Mahāsarasvatī: Śumbha and Niśumbha, subtle pride and the sense of separateness. Inner meaning: the subtle ego that even good people carry. Connect to the Durgā Pūjā: the image of victory is a picture of what she does within us.

SLIDE 9

# Citi: the free Power behind all




## SWAMIJI’S NOTES

Kashmir Śaivism gives the Mother a precise philosophical voice. Sūtra 1: Citi, Consciousness that is free (svatantrā), is the cause (hetu) of the accomplishment (siddhi) of the universe: its appearance, maintenance and dissolution. Notice the word is feminine. Sūtra 2: she unfolds (unmīlayati, as an eye opens) the universe by her own will (svecchayā) on her own screen (svabhittau). No outside clay, no outside canvas. Example for newcomers: in a dream, the dreamer’s own mind is the stage, the actors and the scenery. Link to Sri Ramakrishna: Brahman and Śakti are inseparable, like fire and its power to burn.

SLIDE 10

# She contracts to become us

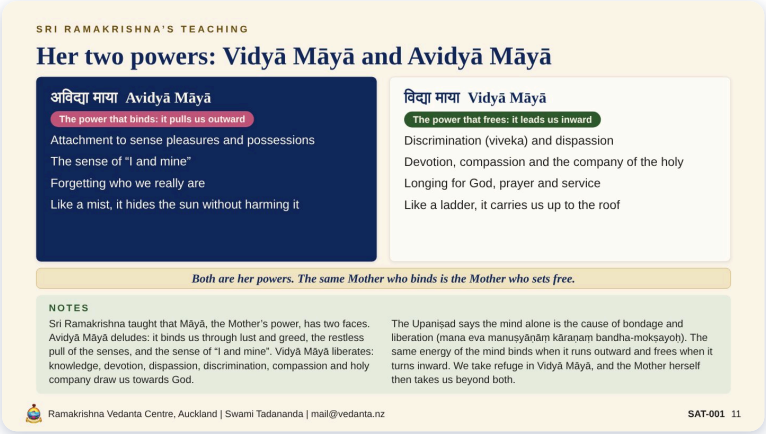



## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Sūtra 3: the universe is manifold (nānā) because of the division into corresponding objects (grāhya) and subjects (grāhaka). Every level of experience has its own knower and its own known. Sūtra 4: the individual experiencer (cetana) is Citi contracted (saṅkoca), and holds the whole universe in contracted form, as a seed holds the tree. Sūtra 5: Citi herself, descending (avarūḍhā) from the plane of pure awareness, contracting in accordance with the objects she perceives (cetya-saṅkocinī), becomes citta, the mind. So the mind is not an enemy to be fought but the Mother in a narrowed form. Sādhanā is the reverse journey: the mind expands back into Citi. This leads directly into the five sheaths, read from the outside in.

SLIDE 11

# Her two powers: Vidyā Māyā and Avidyā Māyā

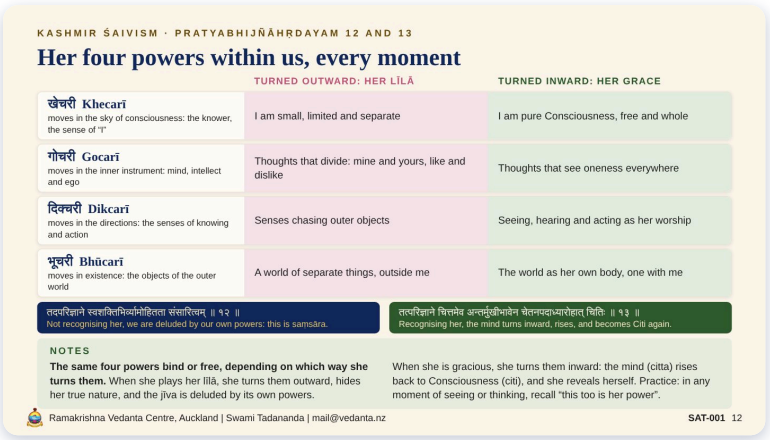



## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Sri Ramakrishna, in the Gospel, speaks of Māyā as having two aspects: avidyā-māyā (lust and greed, which bind) and vidyā-māyā (knowledge, devotion, renunciation, discrimination, compassion and the company of holy men, which lead to God). The ladder and the roof: the steps of vidyā help us climb, and on reaching the roof one sees that the steps are made of the same material as the roof. Please quote his exact words from your copy of the Gospel if you wish to read them. Amṛtabindu Upaniṣad 2: mana eva manuṣyāṇāṃ kāraṇaṃ bandha-mokṣayoḥ. For newcomers: Māyā is not a deceiving demon but the Mother's own creative power, which can hide or reveal.

SLIDE 12

# Her four powers within us, every moment



KASHMIR ŚAIVISM · PRATYABHIJÑĀHṚDAYAM 12 AND 13

## Her four powers within us, every moment

| | TURNED OUTWARD: HER LĪLĀ | TURNED INWARD: HER GRACE |
|---|---|---|
| **खेचरी Khecarī** moves in the sky of consciousness: the knower, the sense of "I" | I am small, limited and separate | I am pure Consciousness, free and whole |
| **गोचरी Gocarī** moves in the inner instrument: mind, intellect and ego | Thoughts that divide: mine and yours, like and dislike | Thoughts that see oneness everywhere |
| **दिक्चरी Dikcarī** moves in the directions: the senses of knowing and action | Senses chasing outer objects | Seeing, hearing and acting as her worship |
| **भूचरी Bhūcarī** moves in existence: the objects of the outer world | A world of separate things, outside me | The world as her own body, one with me |

तदपरिज्ञाने स्वशक्तिभिर्व्यामोहितता संसरित्वम् ॥ १२ ॥
Not recognising her, we are deluded by our own powers: this is saṃsāra.

तत्परिज्ञाने चित्तमेव अन्तर्मुखीभावेन चेतनपदाभ्यारोहात् चितिः ॥ १३ ॥
Recognising her, the mind turns inward, rises, and becomes Citi again.

NOTES

**The same four powers bind or free, depending on which way she turns them.** When she plays her līlā, she turns them outward, hides her true nature, and the jīva is deluded by its own powers.

When she is gracious, she turns them inward: the mind (citta) rises back to Consciousness (citi), and she reveals herself. Practice: in any moment of seeing or thinking, recall "this too is her power".

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SAT-001 12

### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Pratyabhijñāhṛdayam sūtra 12: tad-aparijñāne svaśaktibhir vyāmohitatā saṃsāritvam, when Citi is not recognised, being deluded by one's own powers is transmigratory existence. Kṣemarāja's commentary describes the group of powers (Vāmeśvarī) as Khecarī, Gocarī, Dikcarī and Bhūcarī: khe-carī moves in kha, the sky of consciousness, as the limited experiencer; go-carī in the inner organ (antaḥkaraṇa); dik-carī in the outer senses; bhū-carī in the objective world. In bondage they produce limited agency, differentiating thought, differentiating perception and separate objects; when the Self is recognised, the same powers express universal agency, unifying thought, unifying perception and the world as one's own body. Sūtra 13: tat-parijñāne cittam eva antarmukhī-bhāvena cetana-padādhyārohāt citiḥ, when Citi is recognised, the mind itself, by turning inward and ascending to the state of the knower, becomes Citi.

SLIDE 13

# Opening salutations




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Recording: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8O-v2Rifrwk . The hymn of the gods to the Devī from the Devī Māhātmya (Chaṇḍī), chapter 5. Verses 1 to 5 are salutations to her many forms: the great Goddess, Nature (prakṛti), the fierce and the gentle, Gaurī, the moonlight, Durgā who takes us across difficulties, and the foundation of the world. Then the Yā Devī verses follow on the next slide.

SLIDE 14

# Yā Devī Sarva-bhūteṣu




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

The Yā Devī verses (Devī Māhātmya 5, verses 6 to 26 in this numbering), followed by the two closing verses. Each line salutes the Devī who dwells in all beings in a particular form; after each line the refrain is chanted: namas tasyai namas tasyai namas tasyai namo namaḥ. The forms: Viṣṇumāyā, consciousness, intelligence, sleep, hunger, shadow, power, thirst, forbearance, origin, modesty, peace, faith, beauty, prosperity, activity, memory, compassion, contentment, mother, and even delusion. Verse 27: she presides over the senses of all beings and pervades them. Verse 28: she pervades this whole world as Consciousness (citi).

SLIDE 15

# Where you met her today




## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Bring the chant home. Twelve of the forms from the hymn, each with an everyday example. Invite people to recall where they met her today: at breakfast (hunger), last night (sleep), in a moment of patience. The point for newcomers: spirituality is not separate from ordinary life. Every faculty we use is her power on loan. This prepares the next slide, where the same idea is mapped onto the five sheaths.

SLIDE 16

# Five sheaths, one Power




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Present mode. Then each click reveals one sheath from the outside in, following her contraction, as in sūtras 4 and 5 of the Pratyabhijñāhṛdayam. 1, Ānandamaya: subtlest and most pervasive, bliss interpenetrating all. 2, Vijñānamaya: discernment and the sense of I. 3, Manomaya: feeling, memory, imagination. 4, Prāṇamaya: the breath that breathes us. 5, Annamaya: the body, her most contracted form. Final click: Beyond and within all five, Parāśakti. We are all bubbles in that cosmic Consciousness. In meditation we retrace the path: from body to breath, mind, intellect, bliss, and into her. Source: Taittirīya Upaniṣad 2.1 to 2.5 (Brahmānanda Vallī).

SLIDE 17

# Kuṇḍalinī: the Mother asleep within




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

The lotuses show the traditional petal counts (4, 6, 10, 12, 16, 2 and the thousand-petalled crown) with each centre's bīja mantra: laṁ, vaṁ, raṁ, yaṁ, haṁ and oṁ. The sahasrāra has no bīja: it is beyond sound, where Śakti merges in Śiva. Emphasise safety: devotion and purity, not forceful techniques.

SLIDE 18

# Dakshineswar: a child and his Mother

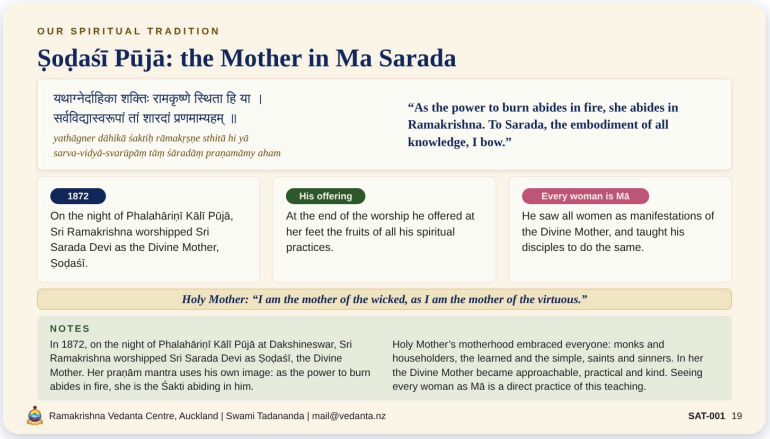



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

The vision is given here as a paraphrase of Sri Ramakrishna's own account (in Swami Saradananda's Sri Ramakrishna, the Great Master, and in the Gospel). Link back to the five sheaths: the ocean of Consciousness he saw is Parāśakti, and each of us is a bubble in her.

SLIDE 19

# Ṣoḍaśī Pūjā: the Mother in Ma Sarada

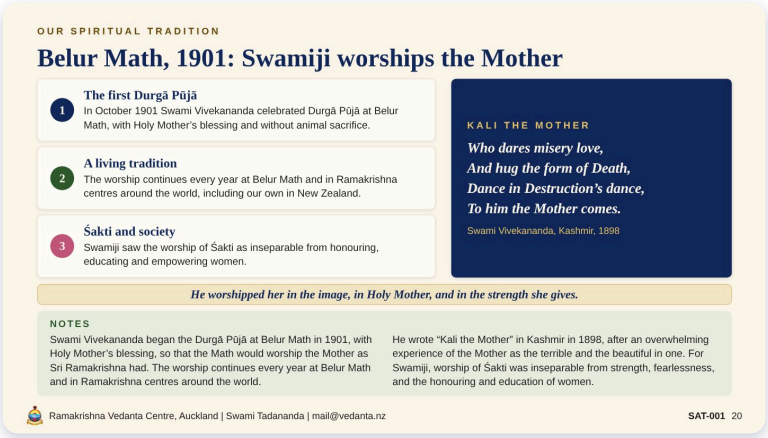



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Chant the praṇām mantra together. Note the echo of slide 5: Sri Ramakrishna said Brahman and Śakti are like fire and its power to burn; the mantra says Holy Mother is that power to burn in him. The Ṣoḍaśī Pūjā took place in June 1872 at Dakshineswar, on the night of Phalahāriṇī Kālī Pūjā. Sri Ramakrishna worshipped her as Ṣoḍaśī (Tripurasundarī) and offered his rosary and the fruits of his sādhanā at her feet.

SLIDE 20

# Belur Math, 1901: Swamiji worships the Mother

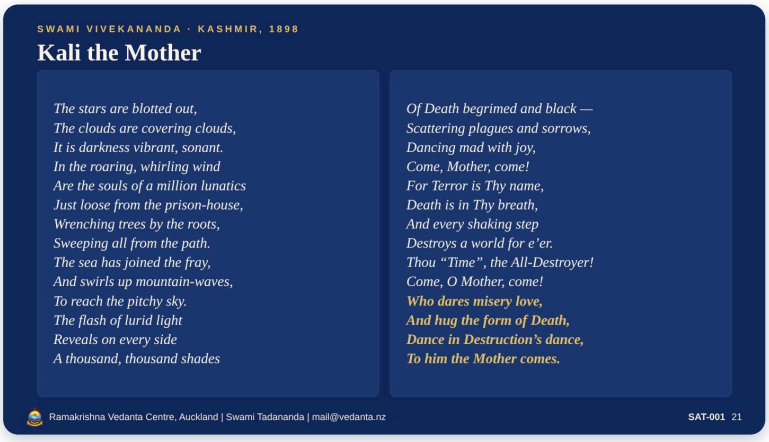



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Swami Vivekananda began the Durgā Pūjā at Belur Math in October 1901, with Holy Mother's permission. There was no animal sacrifice. The worship has continued every year since. Our own Durgā Pūjā in New Zealand stands in this line. The closing lines of "Kali the Mother" (Complete Works, Vol. 4) express the fearless love of the Mother that Swamiji embodied. Swamiji repeatedly taught that a nation rises only when its women are honoured and educated; Śakti worship and respect for women were one idea for him.

SLIDE 21

# Kali the Mother

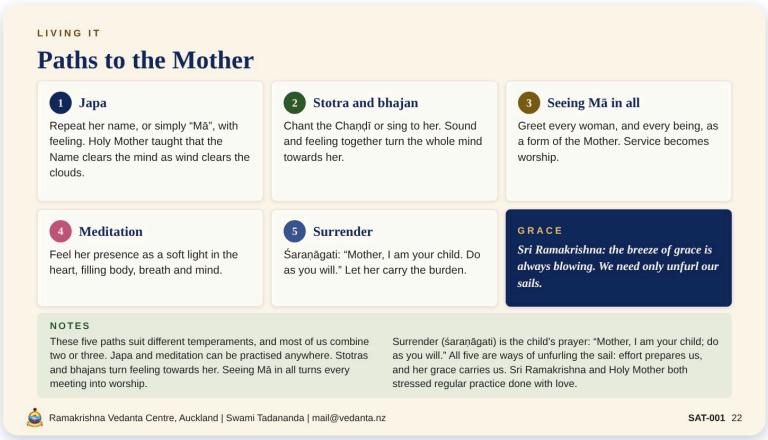



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

"Kali the Mother", written by Swami Vivekananda in Kashmir in 1898 after an overwhelming experience of the Mother, Complete Works, Vol. 4 (poems). Sister Nivedita recounts that he wrote it in a fever of inspiration and fell to the floor exhausted when it was done. Read it slowly, then pause on the last four lines: fearless love of the Mother, accepting the terrible as well as the beautiful, brings her near.

SLIDE 22

# Paths to the Mother

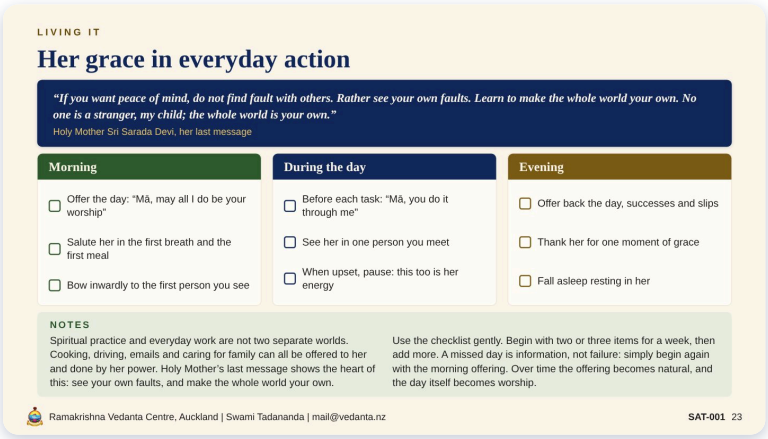



### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Five sādhanas for realising the Mother. Stotra and bhajan: the Chaṇḍī, the Lalitā Sahasranāma, Rāmprasād's songs. Seeing Mā in all: the practice Sri Ramakrishna taught in the Ṣoḍaśī Pūjā. Meditation: leads to the guided meditation shortly. Surrender: the child's prayer. Grace: Sri Ramakrishna's image of the breeze of grace always blowing; we only need to unfurl our sails (paraphrased from the Gospel).

SLIDE 23

# Her grace in everyday action




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Holy Mother's last message, given shortly before she passed away in 1920. It is the practical heart of Mother worship: make the whole world your own. The checklist turns the teaching into small daily actions in the spirit of the Hamilton class: morning offering, offering each task, seeing her in one person, pausing when upset, and offering back the day.

SLIDE 24

# Questions for reflection




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Use this slide to open the questions and answers time, before the guided meditation, or leave it on screen while people reflect. Six questions, from noticing her (1) to the sheaths (2), seeing her in people (3), surrender (4), everyday worship (5), and the fearlessness that comes from knowing we are bubbles in her ocean (6).

SLIDE 25

# Guided meditation: the Mother within




### SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Guided meditation, about ten minutes. Suggested words: Sit steady. Let the breath settle. Each breath, she breathes me. Feel the body: this is the Mother in her most contracted form. Now the breath: this too is You, Mā. A feeling, a thought, the sense of I: this too is You. Rest in the heart, where she shines as a soft golden light. Let the light spread beyond the body, into her boundless ocean. Rest there. Offer the meditation for the welfare of all beings. Om śāntiḥ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ.

SLIDE 26

# Test yourself: a 10-question quiz

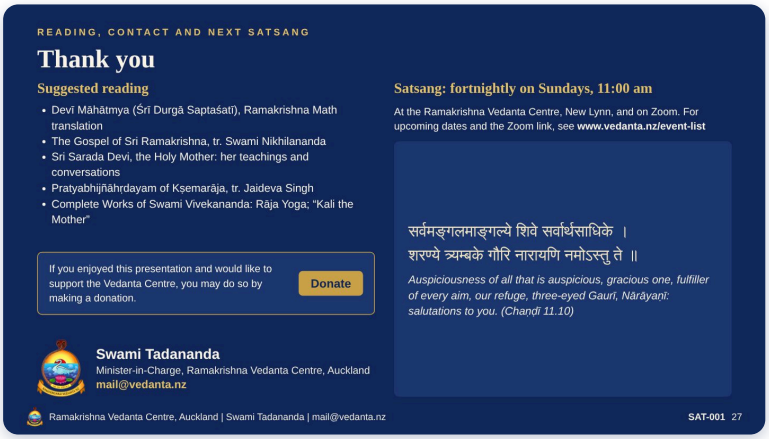



## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

A short revision quiz on today's satsang: ten questions, ten marks each. Invite devotees to scan the code now or at home; the quiz explains each answer and points to the slide to revisit. A longer 25-question quiz for home study will follow.

SLIDE 27

# Thank you




## SWAMIJI'S NOTES

Close with the Sarva-maṅgala-māṅgalye verse (Chaṇḍī 11.10) chanted together, then Ārati and prasād. Thank everyone in the room and on Zoom, and invite them to share these slides with friends and family. Mention the Donate button for anyone who wishes to support the Centre: www.vedanta.nz/donate